
MEETING MINUTES

Diversity, Equity and Inclusion (DEI) Subcommittee Meeting November 19, 2024 @ 5:00 pm

- I. Roll Call and Attendance - 3/0
- II. 2024-40 Consolidation Language for Diversity, Equity and Inclusion (DEI) Support

Be it resolved, as motioned at the November 4, 2024 Regular School Committee Meeting, the following resolution was moved for further discussion to the subcommittee.

2024-40 Offered by Mayor Lungo-Koehn

Consolidation Language for Diversity, Equity and Inclusion (DEI) Support

Whereas the City's DEI Director and ADA Coordinator is supporting School ADA, DEI, Crisis Management, HR, and training needs by being a resource to the School Administration team.

Be it resolved that the DEI Director will continue to be a resource to the School Department including but not limited to the following in the DEI/ADA realm:

- Attendance at parent meetings during challenging transitions (e.g. Principal change overs).
- Interview panel and question design.
- Professional development days (consultation with external trainers for program design, presentation, and support and/or direct training by DEI Director/ADA Coordinator).
- Assist with professional employee discipline cases involving civil rights allegations.
- Civil Rights complaints mediation (e.g. employee to employee, parents to MPS) and consultation to the administrative team on all civil rights related matters.
- Support required training needed after successful conversations with respective collective bargaining unit presidents.
- Support HR, as needed:
 - Consultation regarding ADA/FMLA cross over;
 - Review and guidance of external correspondence when addressing hate related imaging found on school property;
 - Resource sharing (new laws, amendments to laws, case settlements from EEOC and navigational support with HR);

- Recruitment and talent acquisition;
- Sharing of viable candidates from City side; and
- Training support (webinars, formal sessions, etc.).
- Other related items as identified by the administrative team.

Date Submitted: October 31, 2024

Date Requested to be on the Agenda: November 4, 2024

We do not want the DEI Director to be taken away from her day-to-day duties.

What has been happening, what the need is, and what are the skills Ms. Nwajei has that the school side does not have?

Employees of Medford Public Schools are not City employees and so the city side should not have access to school staff information.

- Frances Nwajei elaborated on what her background is and her role as it was and is now.
 - Reassured that no student information is accessible to her.
 - Vague information is all that she needs to look at a situation and make her determination.
 - Support role for students and only when invited.
 - The only time would be a very extreme case in an ADA case, for example, a blind or deaf student needing assistance.
- Her role is as a mediator and in partnership with the administration.
- Training is always ongoing in her role.

Can you estimate how much time you spend on school-related issues

- Things continuously come up and it would be difficult to estimate or give a percentage.
- Safely say at least once a week.
- It's a two-way partnership
- Who are the specific collaborator(s)?
 - Jeanine Camuso
 - Sometimes Joan Bowen
 - Superintendent, depending on the reason for the outreach
- It would be helpful to us for the school budget going forward to be able to have a cost in mind.
- If we were blessed to have a resource in-house, what would that look like?
- Every case has twists and turns that are unpredictable.
- Some employees need more hand-holding than others.

- We have an opportunity to work with Director Nwajei to better our district.
- It is no single person's job. It is very collaborative and a partnership.
- It's a journey where there is no destination.
- Arlington has a city director and a director in the schools
- Somerville has 11 FTEs in their office of Equity and Excellence.
- We are at a crossroads with the passage of the override so the Committee is trying to see if having an FTE to be Director Nwajei's colleague would make sense.
- In Arlington they have a team consisting of school and city side staff.
- Director Nwajei would be a valuable resource and collaborator for recruitment.

Director Nwajei

- Many aspects to the DEI role.
- As a wishlist for Medford- one department with someone that represents the city and someone that represents the schools.

Committee:

When you're going into the school do you find there are some gaps in the school component?

Director Nwajei

We need additional staff for sure.

Committee:

The School Committee has no authority over you (Director Nwajei) so we are not in a position to pass a resolution that would impact your workload. You work for the Mayor.

- Bring back to the larger committee that we start new personnel acting in that role while proposing Director Nwajei with a stipend.
- Extend the stipend through the end of this fiscal year.
- Maintain full collaboration between schools and Director Nwajei.

Recommended Motion for future whole committee meeting:

The Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Subcommittee recommends that Medford Public Schools create a new job description for a school-based DEI director who will work in collaboration with the City of Medford DEI director. Further, the Medford Public Schools will provide an annual stipend to the City of Medford DEI director to compensate for the collaboration and communication with the Medford Public Schools. Further, the Superintendent will make a recommendation for the stipend amount by the December 16, 2024 meeting.

Stipend to be presented by the Superintendent for approval at the December 16,

2024 meeting.

***Motion to approve recommendation and send to full committee by Member Ruseau,
second by Member Olapade - 3/0***

***Motion to adjourn by Member Reinfeld, second by Member Ruseau - 3/0
Meeting adjourned at 6:32 pm***